SHAMEFUL WASTE



A STRING OF EIGHT HIGH-PROFILE PROJECTS UNDER SUCCESSIVE CONGRESS AND BJP REGIMES HAS TURNED INTO CAUTIONARY TALES OF FISCAL SPLURGE AND POOR PLANNING IN JAIPUR AND REST OF THE DESERT STATE

By Rohit Parihar

WHEN THE SUPREME COURT, IN MARCH THIS YEAR, ordered the demolition of kitschy replicas of the 'Seven Wonders' built along the banks of Ajmer's 12th-century Ana Sagar Lake—a protected wetland—it wasn't judicial activism so much as a belated course correction for a folly committed two years ago. Around the same time, Rajasthan chief minister Bhajan Lal Sharma ordered the dismantling of Jaipur's 16-km-long Bus Rapid Transit System (BRTS), a corridor completed 15 years ago but never brought into use. Blamed for traffic chaos and fatal accidents, the BRTS had become emblematic of the state's flawed urban planning.

Elsewhere, there are efforts to salvage ailing projects. A sum of Rs 12,000 crore has been proposed for the overhaul of Jaipur's partially functional and financially bleeding metro rail, originally launched in 2011. Another Rs 50 crore has been allocated for a fresh feasibility study and works for the Dravyavati River rejuvenation project, where an earlier Rs 1,500 crore intervention has only turned the river into a fetid drain. Even a sprawling new Education Hub in Jaipur, built just two years ago but largely unoccupied, is now being reimagined to house branches of national institutions.

When Sharma took office in December 2023,

PARADISE LOST

Once envisioned as an eco-tourism revival project, Jaipur's 17th-century Man Sagar Lake—home to the iconic Jal Mahal—stands ruined. Launched in 1999 under the Congress, the plan included treated sewage inflow, lakeside walkways and heritage conservation. But commercial interests crept in. By 2004–05, the BJP awarded a 99-year lease for just Rs 2.5 crore annually, handing over Rs 15,000 crore worth assets to a private player. In Gehlot's second term, the project morphed into a scandal—land was reclaimed for a proposed mall and hotels, shrinking the lake and leading to overflow. Though courts intervened—Rajasthan HC cancelled the contract in 2012, SC cut lease tenure in 2014—the damage was done. In 2015, the BJP government notified it as a wetland, freezing all activity. Yet violations continued. The NGT fined the civic body Rs 26 lakh in 2024. In February 2025, the SC called out its "unlawful actions" for having "completely destroyed" the lake. The court is now looking into ways to protect what remains. ■

1. JAL MAHAL COMPLEX, JAIPUR

LAUNCHED: 1999 (Congress)
COST: Rs 65 crore (government), Rs 150 crore (private)
STATUS: Out of bounds for public, new works stopped

